

The Fall of the House of Usher

Edgar Allan Poe · 1839

First published: Burton's Gentleman's Magazine, Sep 1839

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

Cover: Jean-Honoré Fragonard, A Young Girl Reading (c. 1770). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Fall_of_the_House_of_Usher (revision 14833569), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about decay of family and mind?
- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about fear and the imagination?
- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about the double?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Fall of the House of Usher	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*decay of family and mind* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Fall of the House of Usher

Focus: a family and a house collapsing together

Content note (premature burial, gothic dread): Sensitive content: Premature burial; gothic dread. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes premature burial; gothic dread.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a storm, she bursts out of her tomb and falls dead on her brother, who dies of terror. The narrator flees as the house splits along the crack and sinks into the tarn.

Background: Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line.

Significance: Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes premature burial; gothic dread.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are unmingled, alleviate, heighten, equivocal, despaired. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings." In this sentence it means: pure; not mixed with anything else. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Fall of the House of Usher would have known. Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line. Why does this story matter? Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for setting.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "The room in which I found myself was very large and lofty." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to a family and a house collapsing together? I circle "profuse", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find setting, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for setting.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of setting. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *The room in which I found myself was very large and lofty. The windows were long, narrow, and pointed, and at so vast a distance from the black oaken floor as to be altogether inaccessible from within. Feeble gleams of encrimsoned light made their way through the trellissed panes, and served to render sufficiently distinct the more prominent objects around; the eye, however, struggled in vain to reach the remoter angles of the chamber, or the recesses of the vaulted and fretted ceiling. Dark draperies hung upon the walls. The general furniture was profuse, comfortless, antique, and tattered. Many books and musical instruments lay scattered about, but failed to give any vitality to the scene. I felt that I breathed an atmosphere of sorrow. An air of stern, deep, and irredeemable gloom hung over and pervaded all.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Setting, Imagery, Symbolism: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Fall of the House of Usher develops the idea of a family and a house collapsing together. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to decay of family and mind? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about a family and a house collapsing together, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes a family and a house collapsing together. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
unmingled (adjective)	pure; not mixed with anything else	*I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
alleviate (verb)	provide physical relief, as from pain	*For several days ensuing, her name was unmentioned by either Usher or myself; and during this period I was busied in earnest endeavors to alleviate the melancholy of my friend.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
heighten (verb)	to increase	*Much that I encountered on the way contributed, I know not how, to heighten the vague sentiments of which I have already spoken.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
equivocal (adjective)	open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead	*I learned, moreover, at intervals, and through broken and equivocal hints, another singular feature of his mental condition.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
despaired (verb)	abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart	*It was, he said, a constitutional and a family evil, and one for which he despaired to find a remedy—a mere nervous affection, he immediately added, which would undoubtedly soon pass off.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
	a feeling of alarm or dread	*He accosted me with trepidation and passed on.*	

trepidation (noun)			Student look-up (not yet verified)
profuse (adjective)	produced or growing in extreme abundance	*The general furniture was profuse, comfortless, antique, and tattered.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
partaking (verb)	have some of the qualities or attributes of something	*One of the phantasmagoric conceptions of my friend, partaking not so rigidly of the spirit of abstraction, may be shadowed forth, although feebly, in words.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
perusal (noun)	a careful reading	*His chief delight, however, was found in the perusal of an exceedingly rare and curious book in quarto Gothic—the manual of a forgotten church—the Vigiliae Mortuorum secundum Chorum Ecclesiae Maguntinae.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
detailed (verb)	explained point by point	*Some of these, as he detailed them, interested and bewildered me; although, perhaps, the terms, and the general manner of the narration had their weight.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with decay of family and mind?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why does the narrator visit the House of Usher? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Roderick wrote asking for his company
2. What flaw does the narrator notice in the house's front? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A barely visible crack running down the wall
3. Who is Madeline? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Roderick's twin sister
4. What happens to Madeline that turns out to be terrible? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: She is entombed while still alive
5. What happens to the house at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: It splits apart and sinks into the tarn

6. Retell the three most important events of “The Fall of the House of Usher” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a storm, she bursts out of her tomb and falls dead on her brother, who dies of terror. The narrator flees…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Fall of the House of Usher”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Fall of the House of Usher” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings.” What does “unmingled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: unmingled: pure; not mixed with anything else.
10. Reread: “For several days ensuing, her name was unmentioned by either Usher or myself; and during this period I was busied in earnest endeavors to alleviate the melancholy of my friend.” What does “alleviate” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: alleviate: provide physical relief, as from pain.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Fall of the House of Usher” suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the imagery in this story shape what we understand about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
4. In the passage that begins “The room in which I found myself was very large and lofty.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Fall of the House of Usher”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Fall of the House of Usher” set up that the rest of The Fall of the House of Usher will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does symbolism appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with decay of family and mind? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
10. Background: Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Fall of the House of Usher” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Fall of the House of Usher”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to fear and the imagination: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The Fall of the House of Usher” treats a family and a house collapsing together with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Fall of the House of Usher see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve decay of family and mind? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

Chapter quiz

1. Why does the narrator visit the House of Usher?
   A. He is lost in a storm
   B. He wants to buy it
   C. Roderick wrote asking for his company
   D. He is a doctor called to Madeline
2. What flaw does the narrator notice in the house's front?
   A. A barely visible crack running down the wall
   B. A missing door
   C. A broken window
   D. A fallen tower
3. Who is Madeline?
   A. The housekeeper
   B. Roderick's wife
   C. The narrator's cousin
   D. Roderick's twin sister
4. What happens to Madeline that turns out to be terrible?
   A. She marries the narrator
   B. She is entombed while still alive
   C. She runs away
   D. She burns the house
5. What happens to the house at the end?
   A. It splits apart and sinks into the tarn
   B. The narrator inherits it
   C. It burns down
   D. It is sold

6. In the line “I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings.”, what does “unmingled” most nearly mean?
   A. to increase
   B. provide physical relief, as from pain
   C. pure; not mixed with anything else
   D. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead
7. In the line “For several days ensuing, her name was unmentioned by either Usher or myself; and during this period I was busied in earnest endeavors to alleviate the melancholy of my friend.”, what does “alleviate” most nearly mean?
   A. to increase
   B. provide physical relief, as from pain
   C. pure; not mixed with anything else
   D. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead

Answer key: 1. C (Roderick wrote asking for his company); 2. A (A barely visible crack running down the wall); 3. D (Roderick's twin sister); 4. B (She is entombed while still alive); 5. A (It splits apart and sinks into the tarn); 6. C (pure; not mixed with anything else); 7. B (provide physical relief, as from pain)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Fall of the House of Usher,” how does Poe show a family and a house collapsing together? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Fall of the House of Usher, how does Poe develop the idea of a family and a house collapsing together? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Fall of the House of Usher develops the idea of a family and a house collapsing together. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of a family and a house collapsing together. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Fall of the House of Usher suggests about a family and a house collapsing together. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and imagery), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses setting in The Fall of the House of Usher to complicate the reader's understanding of a family and a house collapsing together. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Fall of the House of Usher within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a family and a house collapsing together responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Fall of the House of Usher alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a family and a house collapsing together follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Fall of the House of Usher and its treatment of a family and a house collapsing together. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and imagery, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Fall of the House of Usher as evidence for a larger claim about a family and a house collapsing together in The Fall of the House of Usher. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Fall of the House of Usher as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a family and a house collapsing together. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Fall of the House of Usher.

SAT-style questions

1. *Much that I encountered on the way contributed, I know not how, to heighten the vague sentiments of which I have already spoken.*

As used in the text, what does the word "heighten" most nearly mean?

A. to increase

B. have some of the qualities or attributes of something

C. a careful reading

D. explained point by point

2. *The room in which I found myself was very large and lofty. The windows were long, narrow, and pointed, and at so vast a distance from the black oaken floor as to be altogether inaccessible from within. Feeble gleams of encrimsoned light made their way through the trellissed panes, and served to render sufficiently distinct the more prominent objects around; the eye, however, struggled in vain to reach the remoter angles of the chamber, or the recesses of the vaulted and fretted ceiling. Dark draperies hung upon the walls. The general furniture was profuse, comfortless, antique, and tattered. Many books and musical instruments lay scattered about, but failed to give any vitality to the scene. I felt that I breathed an atmosphere of sorrow. An air of stern, deep, and irredeemable gloom hung over and pervaded all.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Fall of the House of Usher"?

A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

B. A family and a house collapsing together

C. Superstition used against a credulous man

D. A reversal that punishes a change of heart

SAT key: 1. A (to increase); 2. B (A family and a house collapsing together)

Whole-book test

The Fall of the House of Usher: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why does the narrator visit the House of Usher?
   A. He is lost in a storm
   B. He wants to buy it
   C. Roderick wrote asking for his company
   D. He is a doctor called to Madeline
2. What flaw does the narrator notice in the house's front?
   A. A barely visible crack running down the wall
   B. A missing door
   C. A broken window
   D. A fallen tower
3. Who is Madeline?
   A. The housekeeper
   B. Roderick's wife
   C. The narrator's cousin
   D. Roderick's twin sister
4. What happens to Madeline that turns out to be terrible?
   A. She marries the narrator
   B. She is entombed while still alive
   C. She runs away
   D. She burns the house
5. What happens to the house at the end?
   A. It splits apart and sinks into the tarn
   B. The narrator inherits it
   C. It burns down
   D. It is sold
6. In the line “I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings.”, what does “unmingled” most nearly mean?
   A. to increase
   B. provide physical relief, as from pain
   C. pure; not mixed with anything else
   D. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead

7. In the line "For several days ensuing, her name was unmentioned by either Usher or myself; and during this period I was busied in earnest endeavors to alleviate the melancholy of my friend.", what does "alleviate" most nearly mean?
   A. to increase
   B. provide physical relief, as from pain
   C. pure; not mixed with anything else
   D. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead
8. As used in the story ("I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings."), what does "unmingled" mean?
   A. pure; not mixed with anything else
   B. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart
   C. have some of the qualities or attributes of something
   D. provide physical relief, as from pain
9. As used in the story ("For several days ensuing, her name was unmentioned by either Usher or myself; and during this period I was busied in earnest endeavors to al"), what does "alleviate" mean?
   A. a feeling of alarm or dread
   B. provide physical relief, as from pain
   C. a careful reading
   D. to increase
10. As used in the story ("Much that I encountered on the way contributed, I know not how, to heighten the vague sentiments of which I have already spoken."), what does "heighten" mean?
    A. produced or growing in extreme abundance
    B. explained point by point
    C. to increase
    D. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead
11. As used in the story ("I learned, moreover, at intervals, and through broken and equivocal hints, another singular feature of his mental condition."), what does "equivocal" mean?
    A. have some of the qualities or attributes of something
    B. pure; not mixed with anything else
    C. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart
    D. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead
12. As used in the story ("It was, he said, a constitutional and a family evil, and one for which he despaired to find a remedy—a mere nervous affection, he immediatel"), what does "despaired" mean?
    A. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart
    B. a careful reading
    C. provide physical relief, as from pain
    D. a feeling of alarm or dread

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how decay of family and mind develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how fear and the imagination develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how the double develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (decay of family and mind, fear and the imagination, the double) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (Roderick wrote asking for his company); 2. A (A barely visible crack running down the wall); 3. D (Roderick's twin sister); 4. B (She is entombed while still alive); 5. A (It splits apart and sinks into the tarn); 6. C (pure; not mixed with anything else); 7. B (provide physical relief, as from pain); 8. A (pure; not mixed with anything else); 9. B (provide physical relief, as from pain); 10. C (to increase); 11. D (open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead); 12. A (abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart)

Essay assignments

Essay: Decay of family and mind

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about decay of family and mind. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops decay of family and mind across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of decay of family and mind. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of decay of family and mind, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of decay of family and mind in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name

your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Fear and the imagination

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about fear and the imagination. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops fear and the imagination across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of fear and the imagination. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of fear and the imagination, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of fear and the imagination in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The double

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about the double. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the double across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the double. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the double, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of the double in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the double in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.